

GENDER



BENDERS

Vidya vs. Ashwat

Minesweeper: How fast can you sweep 30 mines?

2 min
36 sec

After we'd explained the logic of Minesweeper to Vidya, she was game for the challenge, all eager and everything. As we'd expected, she began by clicking a box at random, and proceeded to guess them from around that box. After landing on a mine at every second click attempt (ouch!)—and realising she'd been doing something wrong—she attempted a sweep. Lady luck made up for Vidya's initial loss of time, and apart from the logic she'd seemed to have applied, a couple of random clicks took her safely home.



2 min

"Why not?" said Ashwat when we asked if he would play Minesweeper while being timed against Vidya. We set a target of 30 mines, and Ashwat started with a random sweep of clicks. His first two clicks opened up only a couple of boxes, but with his third click, his field was one-third cleared. He then turned cautious, and we could see he was going about the task logically! Ashwat reached a stalemate with 16 squares to go, but a lucky random click proved a saviour. A blink later, he was through.

procedure has changed. In such a case, an updated copy of the code would be written to Flash for the next time.

In a separate development, Intel is putting in place the Open NAND Flash Interface (ONFI) initiative, which will aim at developing a standard method of using and

implementing a Robson-like system in PCs. ONFI is supposed to take care of most of the details, allowing notebook manufacturers to easily implement the technique in a cost-effective manner.

Windows Vista is expected to support a very similar approach to chopping time off the

boot-up process. And by the way, Intel happens to be a player in the NAND Flash market.

THE ULTRAMOBILE PC

Microsoft's Origami: Still-Born?

Much hype surrounded the word "Origami" early March, and it was shrouded in much mystery. In fact, "origami" was the most-searched-for term on blog search engine Technorati for a while in March. Speculative photographs of Microsoft's latest device sprouted on several gadget sites. And finally, it was revealed that Origami is an ultramobile PC (UMPC). Most of the details are now in, and though it was expected to retail at between \$600 (Rs 27,000) and \$1,000 (Rs 45,000), Samsung is scheduled to ship the first pieces in April, with a model called the Q1. It will be priced much higher than initially reported, at \$1,200 (Rs 54,000). This will be followed by one from Asus in June. Others will be released in Asian markets later.

So what is a UMPC? It's something like a shrunken Tablet PC, offering most of the functionality of a full-fledged PC on a small package. Microsoft claims it can be carried around easily, but at 2 pounds and 7 inches, it's too large for a pocket: perhaps in the side pocket of a backpack.

Specs-wise, the Origami concept sounds OK: Samsung's Q1 will come

with a 900 MHz Celeron M processor, 512 MB of RAM, and a 40 GB hard drive. The touch screen has a resolution of 800 x 480. It also has a CF card slot, two USB ports, a single Ethernet port and stereo speakers. There's also Bluetooth 2.0 and Wi-Fi b+g. The bells and whistles you're likely to see on UMPCs include digital TV-Tuners, Web cams, SD card readers, fingerprint readers and GPS capabilities. All this in something in the range of eight inches. And for input, one can use the touch-screen or the stylus, or connect a keyboard via USB or Bluetooth.

As for the OS, UMPCs will feature new software called the Windows Touch Pack, which allows you to customise the interface and makes applications more touch-screen-friendly. What about Vista? According to a Microsoft FAQ, "UMPCs that meet the Vista hardware requirements will be compatible with the new operating system."

Essentially, the device sounds like a cross between a Pocket PC and a Tablet PC. Battery life is only 2.5 to 3 hours. If the price is, say, \$800, folks are likely to find it too high—because it's not as small as a PDA, and it's not big enough to be, for example, a "proper" gaming device. Who needs this when you can have a PSP? What kind of market would it find? Perhaps as a wireless Web surfing device. Perhaps as a portable movie player, like the Video iPod, only larger. But why not a laptop if laptop functionality is what you want? Well, there's a ton of opinions out there. For

AM2

Socket AM2 is an upcoming platform that supports new 940-pin Athlons, the highlight being support for DDR2 running at 667 MHz and 800 MHz. This platform breaks the limitations that socket 754/939 had, and supports more than 4 GB DDR DIMMS.

AM2 promises to increase working memory frequency and bandwidth, which in turn will enhance overall system performance. Though the socket AM2

platform supports 940 pins, it is incompatible with older 940-pin Opterons. AMD is expected to launch two dual-core CPUs for Socket AM2 on June 6, 2006: the Athlon 64 X2 5000+ and Athlon 64 FX-62. AM2 technology with the supported processors is expected to reduce power consumption and also heat dissipation, which AMD has been aiming to achieve for some time now.

Buzzword
of the MONTH